

Question 16 · Unit 1 · 8 Marks

Evaluate whether HRD should be treated as a strategic function rather than only as an employee training activity.

Introduction

Evaluate means give arguments for, arguments against or limitations, and a reasoned judgement. The question is almost inviting you to support strategic HRD, but a good answer also says training remains important as a tool.

Detailed points

- 1. What ‘only training’ means.** Training is planned learning for job skills, usually short-term. It is necessary. Treating HRD as only training means: calendar of courses, attendance sheets, no link to appraisal, career, climate or strategy.
- 2. Arguments for strategic HRD.** Capability, leadership pipeline, culture and change readiness decide competitive advantage. These are board-level issues. Nadler and Rao already defined HRD more widely than instruction. Evolution of the field supports strategic status.
- 3. Failure of the training-only view.** Popular courses can have high smile-sheet scores and zero job change if climate and strategy are ignored. Skill gaps in a growing firm need systems, not one workshop. Therefore training-only is too narrow for organisational effectiveness.
- 4. Counter-arguments / limits.** Small firms may only need basic skill training. Calling every training ‘strategic’ without data is empty fashion. Strategic status must be earned by diagnosis, integration and results, not by renaming the training cell.
- 5. Training still has a place.** Evaluation should not insult training. Training is a core HRD subsystem. The judgement is about nesting training inside a strategic system, not abolishing it.
- 6. Criteria for the judgement.** Ask: Does people capability affect long-term success? Yes. Can isolated training build that capability reliably? No. Therefore HRD should be strategic.
- 7. What treating HRD as strategic implies.** Seat in strategy discussions, line-manager accountability, integrated subsystems, budget as investment, evaluation at behaviour and results levels.
- 8. Final evaluative sentence.** Yes, HRD should be a strategic function; employee training is a vital instrument of that function, not the whole function.

Conclusion. Give a balanced evaluation and a clear verdict: *strategic HRD with training inside it, not training instead of HRD.*